

LOST IN TRANSITION

Thousands of Sindhi migrants from Pakistan, who have settled in many parts of Madhya Pradesh in search of peace and security are fighting a battle for Indian citizenship

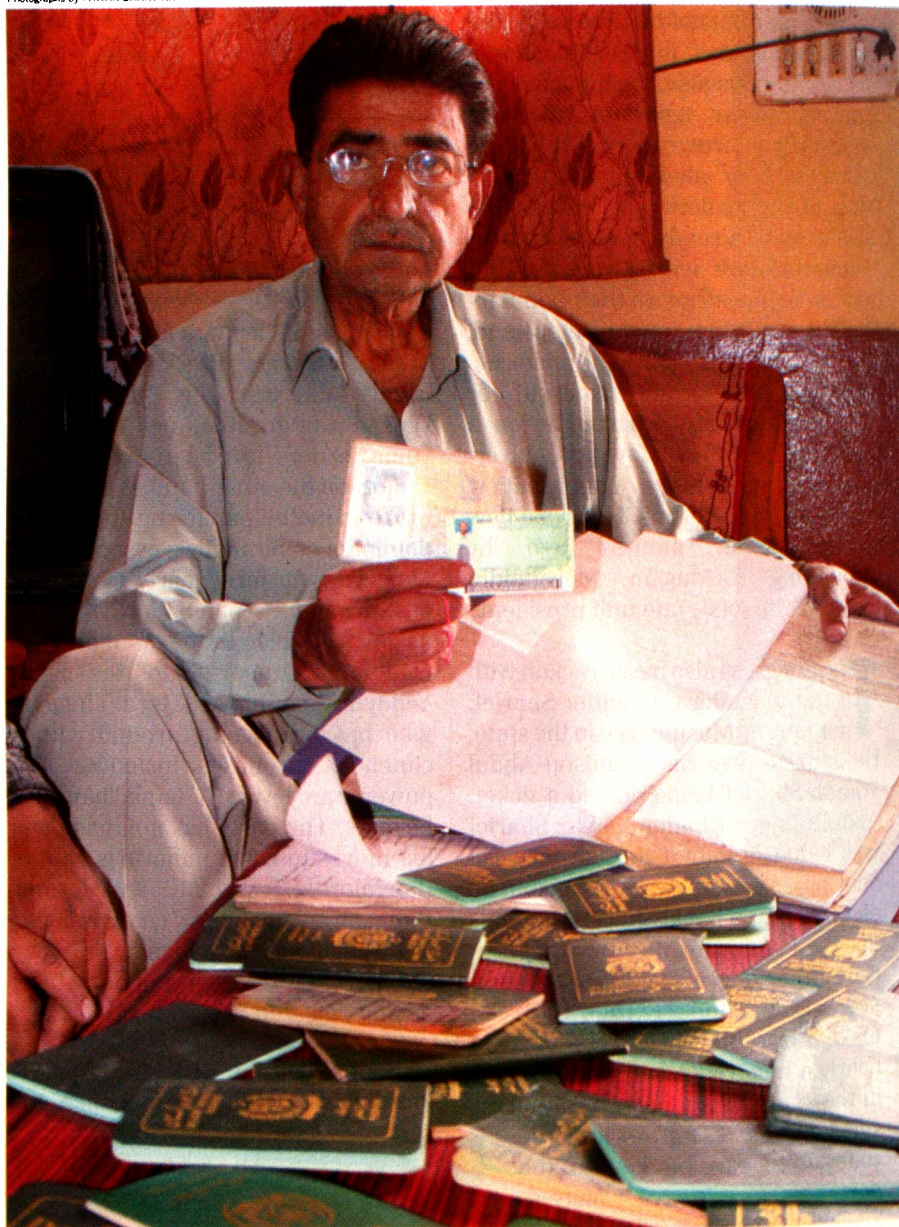
Photographs by PAWAN BHANWAR

■ By Ambreesh Mishra

Horror tales of a bloody Partition might have faded away with the passage of six decades but the tragedies continue to haunt the migrants in many invisible nooks of Madhya Pradesh. Persecuted in their homeland, Sindhi immigrants from Pakistan who have settled in many parts of the state still feel unwanted in the country of their choice. While the first wave of migrants in the aftermath of the Partition in 1947 was granted citizenship immediately, Sindhi Hindus, who have continued to trickle in India in subsequent decades, have been fighting a long battle for citizenship rights. Each of the thousands of families settled mainly in urban centres of the state like Indore, Bhopal and Jabalpur has a tale to tell of their daily struggle to acquire an Indian passport.

Twelve-year-old Priyanka jolts out of her sleep often, fearing the worst for her father. Her mother Rekha can hardly sleep ever since her husband Sanmukhdas Sachdev went to Pakistan to get his passport renewed. The family of three, which migrated in 2002, is trying to make Indore its new abode. Six months ago, after the expiry of his passport, Sachdev was told by the Pakistan High Commission in Delhi that he could not get a new passport in India, unless he provided a new computerised identity card that the Pakistan Government had been issuing of late. He was forced to travel to Pakistan to get a new I-card and has not called in months.

Families like Sachdev's escape from Pakistan looking for security in India, with valid passports and visas, every time there is tension on the borders. They came after the wars in 1965 and 1971. Then they poured in after the Kargil conflict; many came after the 1992 riots and the recent, Gujarat communal conflagration. Balchand Talreja migrated from



LOSING COUNT: Jhamanmal with passports of his 28 family members

a small town of Bhagnari in the Balochistan province of Pakistan following the Babri masjid demolition in 1992. "Growing hatred against Hindus forced me to flee along with my family," says the vegetable vendor who dwells in a single-room tenement in the Dwarikapuri slums of Indore. The 55-year-old barely makes Rs 100 to Rs 125 daily to

feed his wife, two school-going sons and two grandchildren. The first time he was issued a Pakistani passport, it was on the basis of an identity card affixed with his photograph and bearing his thumb impression. It was renewed once but the last time he approached the Pakistan High Commission, he was asked to furnish the computerised I-card.